decision this big had felt like it was out of her hands. For the boys it meant a complete change from everything that had grown familiar. For all of us it meant a new language, a new culture, a new life. We talked to each other, Victoria and I. We talked to our families and to friends. But you can go on talking and never get things any clearer, can't you? The one thing I was absolutely sure of was that if I didn't go with my family, I wasn't going anywhere at all. We were on our way back to England and then, within a couple of days, we'd be off again to the Far East on a promotional tour arranged months ago. I was determined we couldn't run off to the other side of the world before we'd made up our minds.

Sunday June 15 at the house in Sawbridgeworth. Sunshine and a perfect day for a family barbecue. And everyone here to help us with the hardest choice we'd ever had to make. Stay in Manchester and sign that new contract? Or leave England? And for where? The first thing I needed to do was talk to United. I knew the manager was away on vacation so I rang Peter Kenyon. I needed to know exactly where I stood. I asked him what the club felt about the situation and what the boss thought.

'Well, David, if I'm honest with you, it seems to us that the relationship between you and the manager might never be the same again.'

When I asked what his position was, Peter didn't seem to want to commit himself. But then I asked him what he'd do if he was in my shoes.

'Well, looking at it, I'd say you've had great years here but if something else is there, that might be a great challenge for you.'

I'd heard what I'd expected to hear. Even if it hadn't been what I'd been wanting to hear: that United wanted me to stay. I said:

'Knowing how the manager feels, hearing what you're saying to me now, maybe this is the right time for me to think about looking elsewhere.'

I hadn't actually said: I'm leaving. But Mr Kenyon thanked me for what I'd done at Manchester United anyway. I felt the club's mind was made up. Now it was up to me.

I got on with helping get stuff ready for the barbecue and then, about an hour later, I telephoned the Real President, Florentino Perez. Although Tony had met Senor Perez before, it was the first time I'd ever spoken to him. It was the eve of their next to last game of the season. I knew Senor Perez's son wasn't very well and wanted to wish him a speedy recovery. I wanted to wish